WEDNESDAY NIGHT SERVICE

Psalm 32

A Psalm of David · The blessedness of forgiveness

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PSALM 32 · KING JAMES VERSION

1Blessed is he whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered. **2**Blessed is the man unto whom the LORD imputeth not iniquity, and in whose spirit there is no guile. **3**When I kept silence, my bones waxed old through my roaring all the day long. **4**For day and night thy hand was heavy upon me: my moisture is turned into the drought of summer. *Selah.* **5**I acknowledged my sin unto thee, and mine iniquity have I not hid. I said, I will confess my transgressions unto the LORD; and thou forgavest the iniquity of my sin. *Selah.* **6**For this shall every one that is godly pray unto thee in a time when thou mayest be found: surely in the floods of great waters they shall not come nigh unto him. **7**Thou art my hiding place; thou shalt preserve me from trouble; thou shalt compass me about with songs of deliverance. *Selah.* **8**I will instruct thee and teach thee in the way which thou shalt go: I will guide thee with mine eye. **9**Be ye not as the horse, or as the mule, which have no understanding: whose mouth must be held in with bit and bridle, lest they come near unto thee. **10**Many sorrows shall be to the wicked: but he that trusteth in the LORD, mercy shall compass him about. **11**Be glad in the LORD, and rejoice, ye righteous: and shout for joy, all ye that are upright in heart.

The Blessedness of Forgiveness

PSALM 32:1–2

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> *Blessed is he whose transgression is forgiven, whose sin is covered. Blessed is the man unto whom the LORD imputeth not iniquity, and in whose spirit there is no guile.*

Psalm 32 opens with a very familiar and important doctrine, the understanding of God's forgiveness for sin in the saved believer's life. This foundational fact is repeated by Paul in the letter to the Romans:

ROMANS 4:6–8

> *Even as David also describeth the blessedness of the man, unto whom God imputeth righteousness without works, Saying, Blessed are they whose iniquities are forgiven, and whose sins are covered. Blessed is the man to whom the Lord will not impute sin.*

The truth is that, in Christ, whether it was in David's day, or Paul's or our own, God forgives believer's past transgressions, covers our current sin, and will not hold our future sins and iniquity against us.

This positional standing of righteousness before God, despite our sins, through His imputed righteousness — the Righteousness of Christ, is made possible, through the atonement of Jesus' blood, and by the Holy Spirit, by the renewal, the regeneration, the quickening of our spirit — the new man within us. Blessed is the man in whose spirit there is no guile.

We are given the Spirit of truth, that we may acknowledge our sin, knowing that we are forgiven of all sin — first, not by works but by faith. The same good news today as in David's day. And this Psalm serves as an evangelical appeal.

The lack of guile, or cunning duplicity and dishonesty, is both a feature of having the Spirit of truth within us, but is also the understanding that not lying to God and ourselves about our own sin is necessary for the blessings that come from forgiveness. Confession is good for the soul.

The Weight of Silence

PSALM 32:3–5

PSALM 32:3–5

> *When I kept silence, my bones waxed old through my roaring all the day long. For day and night thy hand was heavy upon me: my moisture is turned into the drought of summer. Selah. I acknowledged my sin unto thee, and mine iniquity have I not hid. I said, I will confess my transgressions unto the LORD; and thou forgavest the iniquity of my sin. Selah.*

David writes of a man who kept his silence, who hadn't called upon the name of the Lord, who suffered in their sins — bones waxing old and dried up by their roaring in the daytime, the heaviness of their iniquity weighing on them at night. This of course applies to the lost, in that their conscience, if it has not been seared by reprobation, should eat at them. Convicting them, to bring them to make a decision about Christ. But it also applies to the saved, who are withholding confession to God and deceiving themselves about the wrong we may do.

The honesty and humility of acknowledging sin, not hiding anything from God, not remaining silent, confessing our transgressions unto the Lord, and knowing we are forgiven, is a blessing. Sinning throughout the day and being kept up at night by their conscience, being convicted in the Spirit, gives way to the peace that passes understanding — through the forgiveness that is given to us by God's mercy and grace.

1 JOHN 1:6–9

> *If we say that we have fellowship with him, and walk in darkness, we lie, and do not the truth: But if we walk in the light, as he is in the light, we have fellowship one with another, and the blood of Jesus Christ his Son cleanseth us from all sin. If we say that we have no sin, we deceive ourselves, and the truth is not in us. If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.*

Seek the Lord While He May Be Found

PSALM 32:6

PSALM 32:6

> *For this shall every one that is godly pray unto thee in a time when thou mayest be found: surely in the floods of great waters they shall not come nigh unto him.*

David reminds us that there is a time where God may be sought, before it is too late.

ISAIAH 55:6

> *Seek ye the LORD while he may be found, call ye upon him while he is near.*

God's Spirit will not always strive with man. There comes a time when those that put off or reject the truth, not acknowledging that they are sinners, lying to God and themselves, are no longer able to come to Him, where He no longer extends His hand, because they have hardened their hearts and will not seek Him, even as they face destruction.

HEBREWS 4:7

> *Again, he limiteth a certain day, saying in David, To day, after so long a time; as it is said, To day if ye will hear his voice, harden not your hearts.*

We have the example of those who, in the days of Noah, mocked him for his faith in preparing the ark, and whose disobedient spirits — to whom Christ preached to in Hell — were destroyed by the flood, never coming nigh unto God. Just as those left to God's wrath in the time to come will not repent, despite the horrors of His judgment.

REVELATION 9:20–21

> *And the rest of the men which were not killed by these plagues yet repented not of the works of their hands, that they should not worship devils, and idols of gold, and silver, and brass, and stone, and of wood: which neither can see, nor hear, nor walk: Neither repented they of their murders, nor of their sorceries, nor of their fornication, nor of their thefts.*

For the lost, there is a time where God no longer extends His hand, where He gives them up and gives them over, to hold the truth in unrighteousness and believe lies, condemning themselves.

But Christians can also put off acknowledging and turning from the sin in their lives as well. We can lie to ourselves, rationalize it, and ignore the chastening of God.

HEBREWS 10:26–31

> *For if we sin wilfully after that we have received the knowledge of the truth, there remaineth no more sacrifice for sins, But a certain fearful looking for of judgment and fiery indignation, which shall devour the adversaries… It is a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God.*

Now Is the Day of Salvation

THE EVANGELICAL APPEAL

There is a time, it is today. There is a day, and it is the present. If you haven't accepted the truth that we are sinners in need of salvation, and that it is offered as a free gift to all who believe, through the grace of Almighty God — now is the time.

2 CORINTHIANS 6:2

> *(For he saith, I have heard thee in a time accepted, and in the day of salvation have I succoured thee: behold, now is the accepted time; behold, now is the day of salvation.)*

Those who have heard and responded to the truth, who in the appointed day prayed unto Him, can rest assured that we are saved. But understand that God will chasten us, and can even call us home if we continue in sin.

The promises of God to His children who walk in His ways are a blessing. Getting right with God is its own reward.

Thou Art My Hiding Place

PSALM 32:7–9

PSALM 32:7–9

> *Thou art my hiding place; thou shalt preserve me from trouble; thou shalt compass me about with songs of deliverance. Selah. I will instruct thee and teach thee in the way which thou shalt go: I will guide thee with mine eye. Be ye not as the horse, or as the mule, which have no understanding: whose mouth must be held in with bit and bridle, lest they come near unto thee.*

This is the hope we have — the same hope the congregations of the children of Israel sang of in the temple of Solomon, with the songs of his father David echoing this blessed promise, centuries before the first coming of Christ Jesus.

And God responds to His children, in this inspired Psalm, promising to teach and guide us in His ways. He asks we come willingly, that we have the understanding to walk with Him, and not be like the horse or mule, needing a bit and bridle to pull us along. His yoke is light. The burden is easy.

Be Glad and Rejoice

PSALM 32:10–11

PSALM 32:10–11

> *Many sorrows shall be to the wicked: but he that trusteth in the LORD, mercy shall compass him about. Be glad in the LORD, and rejoice, ye righteous: and shout for joy, all ye that are upright in heart.*

The wicked may suffer their sorrows of their own making, but we who are forgiven by His mercy — because we trust in the Lord — are preserved. What an amazing relief to know we are already forgiven; that we may come boldly before God to sing His praises, glorifying Him for His mercies' sake.

Amen!

DEEPER STUDY

Transgression, Sin & Iniquity

While it isn't entirely wrong to take the words transgression, sin and iniquity and use them interchangeably, they do carry subtle differences in their meaning.

Transgression

Transgression is the wilful rebellion against the truth of God and His commands. The transgression of Adam, for example, having one law to obey, and choosing of their own volition (even as Eve was deceived, Adam most assuredly knew better), deciding to be disobedient.

Sin

Sin, which the Bible says is the transgression of the Law, also carries with it the idea of missing the mark, falling short.

ROMANS 3:23

> *For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God.*

We aren't able, in the flesh, to hit the mark — the target being the perfect holiness of God. Only Jesus Christ did.

2 CORINTHIANS 5:21

> *For he hath made him to be sin for us, who knew no sin; that we might be made the righteousness of God in him.*

Iniquity

Iniquity comes from the Hebrew word Avon, meaning to twist, bend, or distort — the perverted and crooked nature of fallen man. The bent toward evil, the perverted character that drives the outward actions. It is the guile or deceit mentioned in verse 2 coupled with reflexive actions to do evil to others. The propensity to lie, to steal, to lust, to covet.

Our natural tendencies toward willful rebellion, to sin, and to lie to ourselves and others — including God — about the evil that we do.

ISAIAH 53 · THE CLEARED LEDGER

Taken Together: The Blessed Assurance

Taken together, the blessed assurance found in verse 1–2, that our transgressions, sins and iniquities are eternally forgiven demonstrates the mercy and grace of our Lord towards His children, through the suffering of Jesus.

ISAIAH 53:5–6

> *But he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed. All we like sheep have gone astray; we have turned every one to his own way; and the LORD hath laid on him the iniquity of us all.*

He suffered these things for our iniquity and transgressions, that we may be purged — that His righteousness be imputed on our ledger, even as His blood blots away our sins.

1 JOHN 2:1–2

> *My little children, these things write I unto you, that ye sin not. And if any man sin, we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous: And he is the propitiation for our sins: and not for ours only, but also for the sins of the whole world.*

Propitiation is a big word that means a sacrifice that turns away God's holy anger against sin. Jesus took the punishment that people deserved. The payment for the wages of sin we have accrued.

Our transgressions are forgiven, our sin is covered, our iniquity will not be added to our account, because we are justified in Christ. This accounting is a spiritual gift, applied to the ledger — that in judgment, we are found not guilty by God. Justified, just as I'd never sinned.

(Theologians call this Penal Substitutionary Atonement — the idea that Jesus paid the price of the debt we owe, so that we do not have to receive the wages of sin. Many professing Christian sects reject this idea, despite the clear teaching of scripture on the propitiation. But whatever you want to call it, it is undeniable that Christ suffered that those who trust on Him won't.)

On the cross, Jesus carried away our rebellion, covered our failures with His blood, and cleared the ledger of our crooked nature by imputing His own perfect righteousness to us — past, present and future — that we may be made the righteousness of God.

DEEPER STUDY

The Day of Atonement

The concept of atonement — by the sacrifice, the scapegoat, and the blood — is established in Leviticus 16.

The Sin Offering

LEVITICUS 16:3, 5

> *Thus shall Aaron come into the holy place: with a young bullock for a sin offering, and a ram for a burnt offering… And he shall take of the congregation of the children of Israel two kids of the goats for a sin offering, and one ram for a burnt offering.*

Aaron first brought a sin offering for himself and his own household, then a sin offering on behalf of the whole congregation — no priest, however faithful, could stand before God apart from his own need for atonement first.

The Scapegoat

LEVITICUS 16:8, 10, 21–22

> *And Aaron shall cast lots upon the two goats; one lot for the LORD, and the other lot for the scapegoat… But the goat, on which the lot fell to be the scapegoat, shall be presented alive before the LORD, to make an atonement with him, and to let him go for a scapegoat into the wilderness… And Aaron shall lay both his hands upon the head of the live goat, and confess over him all the iniquities of the children of Israel, and all their transgressions in all their sins, putting them upon the head of the goat… And the goat shall bear upon him all their iniquities unto a land not inhabited.*

The confessed sins of the people were laid upon the living goat, which was sent away, carrying that guilt out of the camp and out of sight — a picture of sin actually removed, not merely covered over.

The Blood at the Mercy Seat

LEVITICUS 16:15, 18–19

> *Then shall he kill the goat of the sin offering, that is for the people, and bring his blood within the vail… and sprinkle it upon the mercy seat, and before the mercy seat… And he shall sprinkle of the blood upon it with his finger seven times, and cleanse it, and hallow it from the uncleanness of the children of Israel.*

Only the high priest, only once a year, only by blood, could come within the veil — and even then, the atonement had to be renewed again the following year.

LEVITICUS 16:29–30

> *And this shall be a statute for ever unto you: that in the seventh month, on the tenth day of the month, ye shall afflict your souls, and do no work at all… For on that day shall the priest make an atonement for you, to cleanse you, that ye may be clean from all your sins before the LORD.*

Rather than the picture of the imperfect sacrifice, the blood of bulls and goats which could never take away our sin, we have the flawless Lamb, Who took away the sins of the world, and Who is both the ultimate High Priest, and the one blood sacrifice for all time.

HEBREWS 10:10–14

> *By the which will we are sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all. And every priest standeth daily ministering and offering oftentimes the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins: But this man, after he had offered one sacrifice for sins for ever, sat down on the right hand of God; From henceforth expecting till his enemies be made his footstool. For by one offering he hath perfected for ever them that are sanctified.*

He had no sin of His own to sacrifice for. He did not enter a man-made temple, but Heaven itself. He did not offer the blood of animals, but His own flawless blood upon the Mercy Seat in Heaven.

Because of what Jesus did as both the High Priest and the Sacrifice, the work is finished. The ledger is cleared permanently. God no longer imputes our iniquity, our sins are eternally covered, and our transgressions have been carried as far as the east is from the west. And God will remember them no more.

The Priest Who Sat Down

HEBREWS 10:11–14

HEBREWS 10:11

> *And every priest standeth daily ministering and offering oftentimes the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins.*

In the physical Tabernacle and the Temple of Solomon, there were no chairs. A priest could never sit down, because his job was never done. The blood of bulls and goats only provided a temporary cover for the remembrance of sins, made again every year — meaning the priest had to stay on his feet, continuously working, because he could never truly take away sins.

But then we see Jesus, the author and, most importantly, the finisher of our faith, sit down, on the right hand of the Father.

HEBREWS 10:12–14

> *But this man, after he had offered one sacrifice for sins for ever, sat down on the right hand of God; From henceforth expecting till his enemies be made his footstool. For by one offering he hath perfected for ever them that are sanctified.*

The contrast of those who stood, continually ministering, versus Jesus, Who sat down forever — having perfected them that are sanctified — is a subtle but crucial detail. An interesting side note to the study, that we shouldn't overlook.